

project.org

LIBRARY LESSON PLAN

Harlem Renaissance Library Session

Grades 3–5 · 40 minutes · Research skills + close reading

THE 40 MINUTES

5 min	7 min	5 min	18 min	5 min
HOOK	READING	ART LOOK	ACTIVITY CARDS	SHARE

SESSION GOALS

What students will do

Students will: use the exhibition and library resources to practice research skills; connect primary sources (poems, art, music) to historical context; develop descriptive and analytical writing; and understand how the library is a portal to the past — the stories here are the same ones the Harlem Renaissance artists were creating.

PREPARATION

- **Pull and display:** 8–10 relevant library books (see recommendations, page 2)
- **Tables set:** differentiated activity cards, pencils; optionally set up 2–3 research stations with books open to relevant sections
- **Project:** Great Migration Map and one Douglas image for whole-group opening

SESSION FLOW

0–5 MIN Opening hook	Show the Great Migration Map. *"In 1915, a Black family in Georgia could be arrested for almost nothing, couldn't vote, and would never own the land they farmed. A letter arrives from Chicago: 'Come north. There are factory jobs. The schools are better.' Over the next 50 years, 6 million people made that decision. The whole of Harlem changed because of it. Today we're going to look at what they created when they got there."*
5–12 MIN Whole-group reading	Read aloud one Langston Hughes poem (teacher choice — "I, Too" works well; "Mother to Son" also excellent). Ask: What do you notice about the language? Who is speaking? What is the argument? How is this poem like a letter, a protest, and a prayer all at once?
12–17 MIN Art and source look	Show Douglas, *Song of the Towers*. Quick pair-share: two observations + one question. Introduce the idea that the painting and the poem were made at the same time, in the same neighborhood — Douglas and Hughes knew each other.
17–35 MIN Activity cards	Students work on differentiated cards. Encourage library book use for the Red-level research task. Circulate and ask probing questions: *"How do you know? Where's your evidence? What else does this make you wonder?"*
35–40 MIN Share and close	One student each from Yellow and Red shares their most interesting finding. *"The books on these shelves are a direct line to the people we studied today. The library is where their voices are still alive."*

MINI MUSEUM CONNECTION

Option 1 — Visit the Exhibition: Bring your class to experience the phonograph, the Great Migration Map, the Jazz Lab, and more.

Option 2 — Virtual Visit:

minimuseumproject.org/exhibitions/harlem-renaissance

BOOK RECOMMENDATIONS · GRADES 3–5

BIOGRAPHY AND HISTORY

Langston Hughes: A Biography — Milton Meltzer — comprehensive, accessible

Zora Hurston and the Chinaberry Tree — William Miller — picture-book biography

Duke Ellington: The Piano Prince — Andrea Davis Pinkney — excellent at this level

Stompin' at the Savoy: The Story of Norma Miller — Norma Miller with Alan Govenar — Lindy Hop at the Savoy Ballroom

PRIMARY TEXT ACCESS

Poetry for Young People: Langston Hughes — selected with classroom notes

The Dream Keeper and Other Poems — Langston Hughes — designed for young readers

Soul Looks Back in Wonder — Tom Feelings — anthology with Harlem Renaissance figures

Harlem Renaissance: A Brief History with Documents — higher level, for Red extension

Online — The Poetry Foundation (poetryfoundation.org) and the Academy of American Poets (poets.org) both offer many Hughes poems free

RESEARCH SKILLS INTEGRATION

This session is an ideal opportunity to integrate research skills instruction:

- **Finding a book:** Model using the catalog to find Harlem Renaissance books by subject heading
- **Using an index:** Show students how to use the index in a biography to find specific information quickly
- **Evaluating sources:** Ask: what's the difference between reading a poem Langston Hughes wrote vs. reading a book about Langston Hughes? Which is a primary source?
- **Note-taking:** Red-level students should practice paraphrasing — not copying — from sources they find

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Paintings to project (in copyright, so not printed; each title links to the museum's page): Aspects of Negro Life: Song of the Towers (1934)